

The Agency Fund 

APPLICATIONS SESSION · AGENCY IN INSTITUTIONAL AND HUMAN CAPITAL DEVELOPMENT

Applications of “agency”

Lessons from The Agency Fund and its AI for Global Development Accelerator

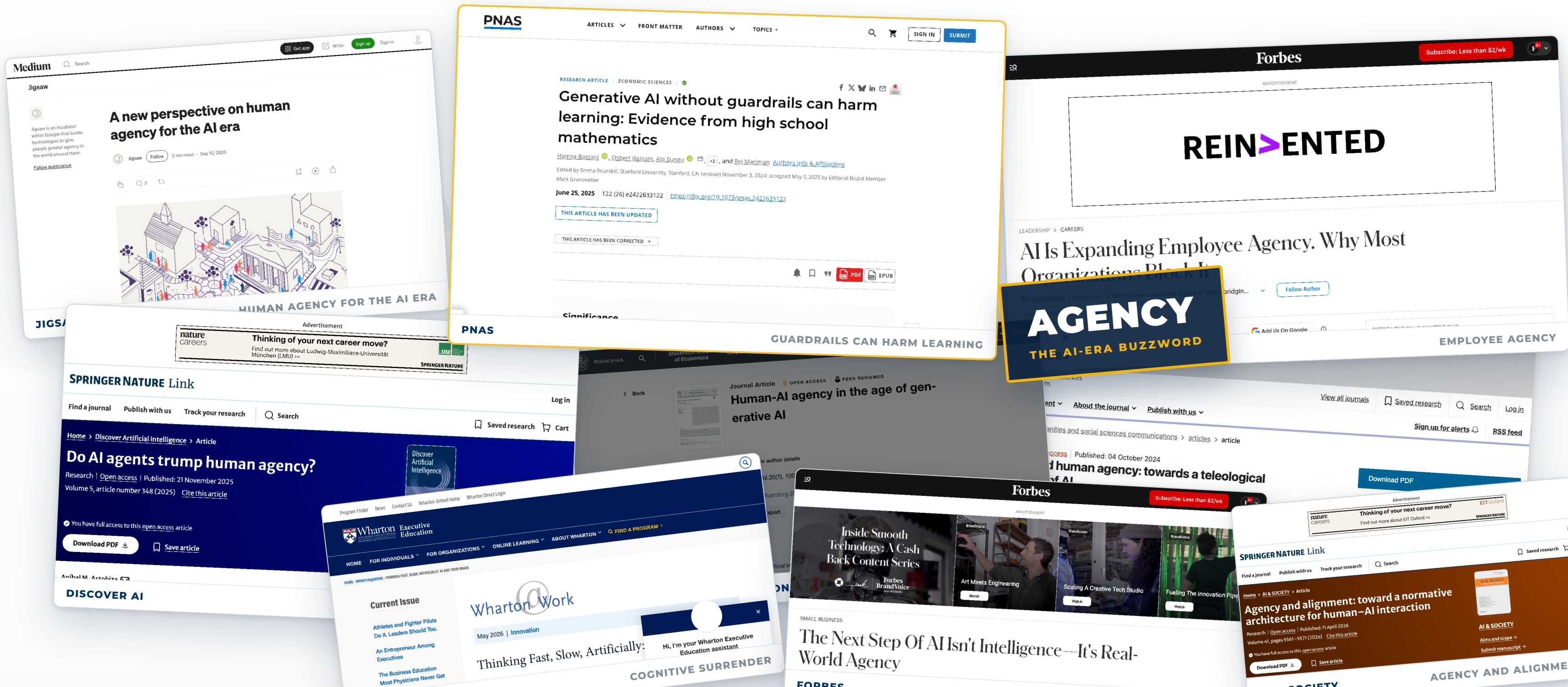
Zezen Wu · The Agency Fund · zezhen@agency.fund

Princeton University · September 26, 2026

If you speak a second language, think about the word “agency” in your own language.

Is there a good translation?

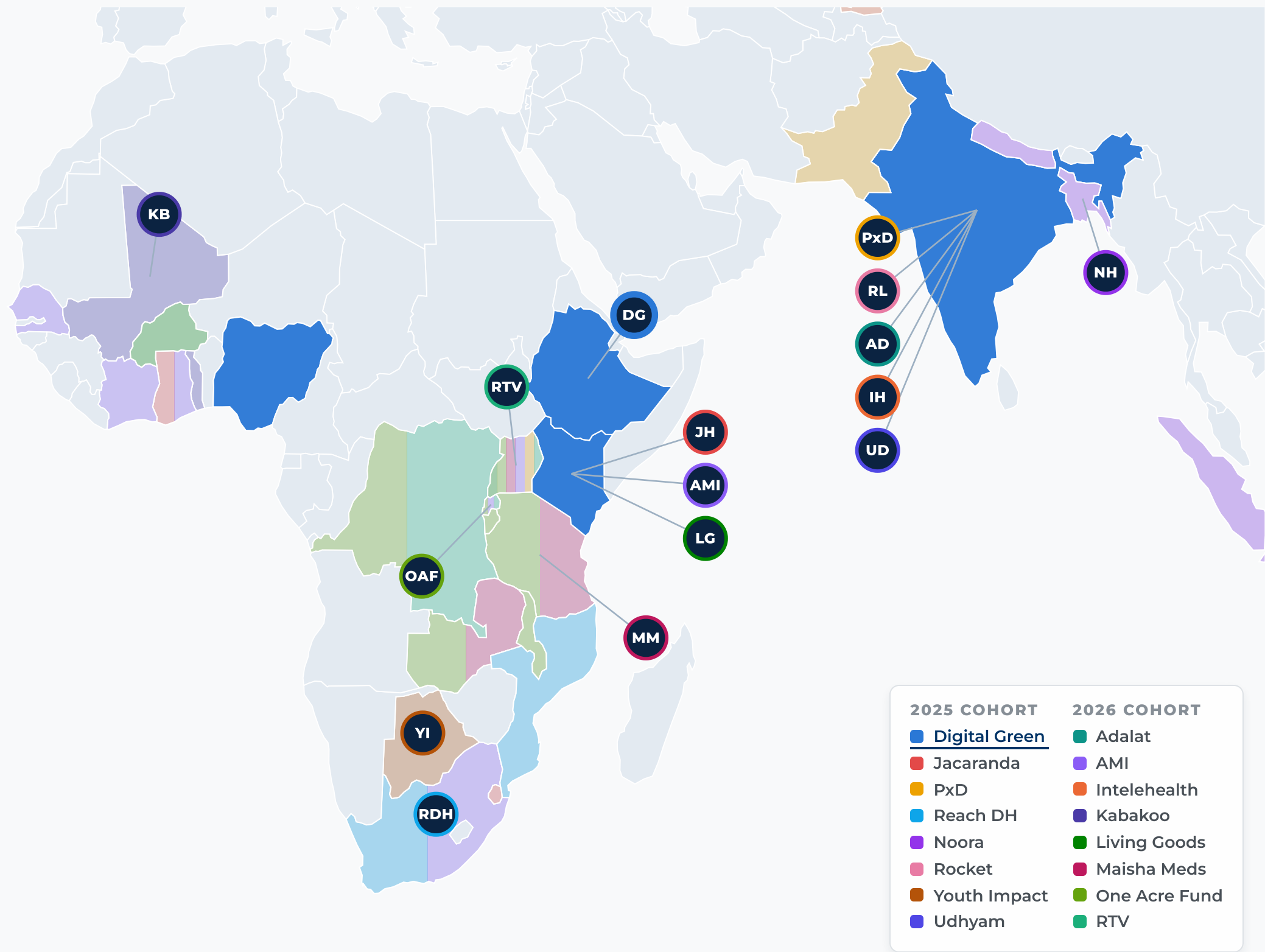
AI can expand agency, and it can hamper it.



Sources: [Jigsaw](#); [Bastani et al.](#), [PNAS](#); [Shaw & Nave, SSRN](#); [Forbes employee agency](#); [Forbes real-world agency](#); [Forbes human agency](#); [Discover AI](#); [AI & Society](#); [Nature HSSC](#); [Human-AI agency](#).

We worked with NGOs globally to design and evaluate their AI products through accelerator programs.

INTERACTIVE Click the map, chips, or legend to focus an org · click empty space to clear, or Reset



Digital Green
2025 COHORT

FarmerChat

A multilingual AI agronomy advisor for smallholder farmers, using text, voice, and images to deliver localized recommendations.

- L1 · MODEL** Model stack is live across 16 languages, with text, voice, image evals and over 100% improvement over the base model.
- L2 · PRODUCT** 1M+ users have generated 8M+ queries; 30% are monthly active and average 8.7 queries per month.
- L3 · USER** About 70% of active users report applying FarmerChat advice; 80% share advice with peers.
- L4 · IMPACT** Kenya assessment finds adoption of cost-saving practices; income and climate-resilience outcomes are in ongoing RCTs.

AI PRODUCT IN: INDIA · KENYA · NIGERIA · ETHIOPIA · BRAZIL
ORGANIZATION OPERATES IN: INDIA · KENYA · NIGERIA · ETHIOPIA · BRAZIL

Working with these organizations surfaced **two gaps related to human agency** for AI products in the social sector.

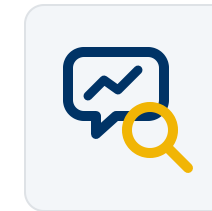


THE DESIGN GAP

AI products are built to optimize service delivery, rather than explicitly to strengthen people's agency.

Despite AI's potential to strengthen human agency, NGO products often treat agency as a byproduct rather than an explicit design objective.

Decades of research in [psychological science](#) and [psychologically wise interventions](#) identify agency as a key mechanism for improving development outcomes, yet it is rarely **intentionally built into AI design, testing, or iteration.**



THE MEASUREMENT GAP

AI products are underused as windows into how human agency evolves.

Many products may not generate as many signals of agency as tools like ChatGPT or Claude Code do. Even when these signals exist, they often come from power users, and the field lacks a shared standard or analytical tools for **measuring and interpreting agency** inside human-AI digital traces. Recent advances in LLM as a measurement tool (e.g., [OpenAI's Gabriel](#) and [Google's Langextract](#) offer promising solutions beyond traditional NLP methods.)

Example: Which health AI chatbot better promotes agency?

INFORMATION DELIVERY

<

A

A²C Health Line

AI assistant · online

Today

hello. my feet r swelling in the evening. i am 7 months pregnant

10:14 ✓

Hello Priya. Mild evening swelling is common in month 7. It helps to:
1. Rest with your feet raised.
2. Drink water through the day.
3. Avoid standing for long.
Go to the clinic if swelling is sudden or comes with headache or blurred vision.

10:15

ok. can i still do house work

10:22 ✓

Light housework is fine. Avoid heavy lifting and take short breaks.

10:23

ok thank you

10:26 ✓

Message

GOAL SETTING AND NAVIGATION

<

A

A²C Health Line

AI assistant · online

Today

hello. my feet r swelling in the evening. i am 7 months pregnant

10:14 ✓

Hello Priya. Evening swelling is common in month 7, and resting with feet raised helps. Have you managed your ANC check-up this month?

10:15

not yet. clinic is far and my husband takes the scooter for work

10:21 ✓

That is a real constraint. The 7th-month check matters — they will look at this swelling and your BP. Which day is he home?

10:22

thursday, home by 2

10:24 ✓

Then a plan: Thursday at 3 he drops you at the clinic. Carry your mother-child card. Shall I remind you at 1?

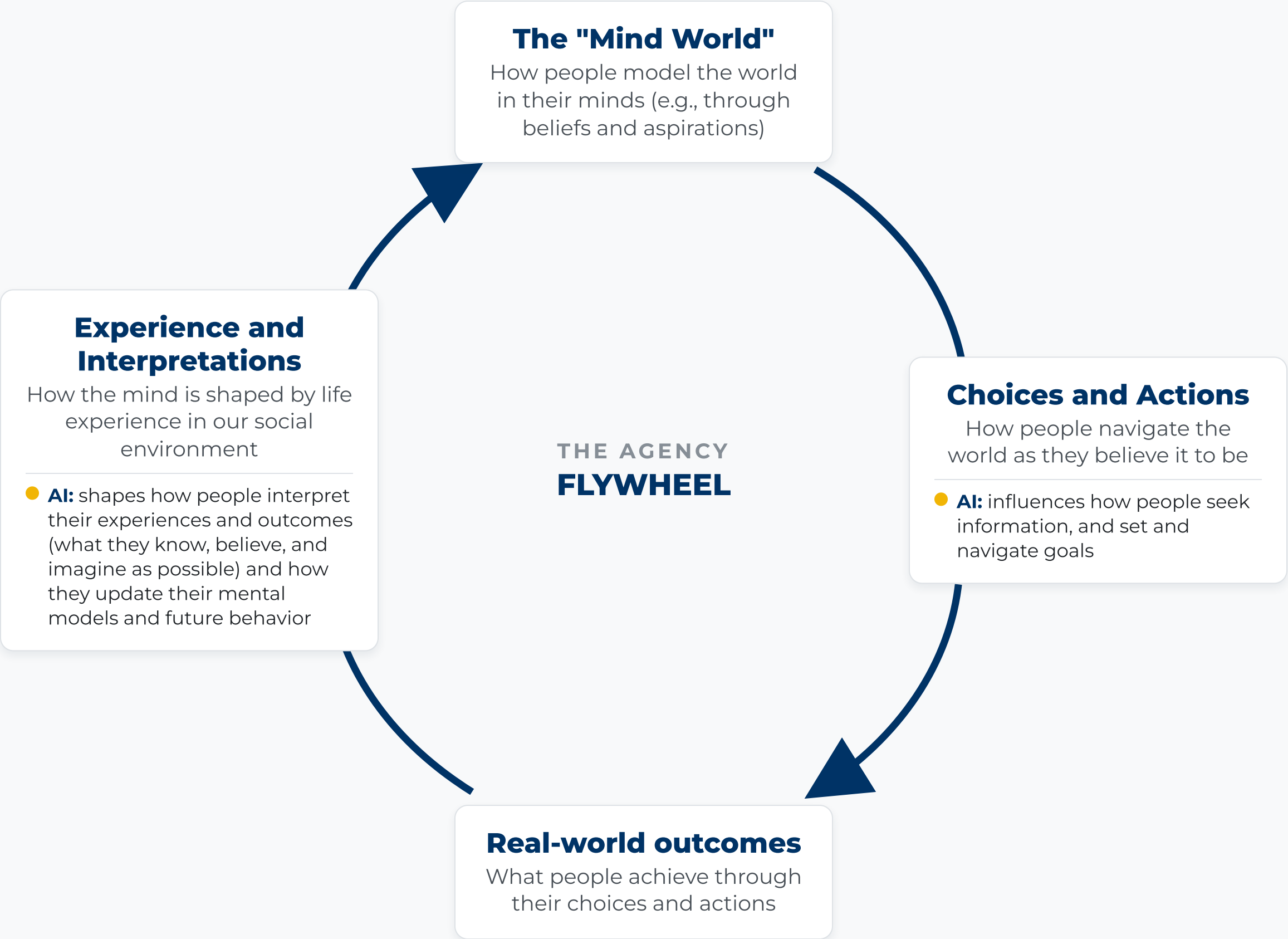
10:25

yes pls. thursday 3 pm i will go

10:27 ✓

Message

Our worldview of agency in a flywheel



- The loop can turn in either a good or a bad way.**
When it turns well, capable choices bring results that promote a positive cycle.
When it turns badly, failed choices result in a negative cycle.
- AI products can influence how the flywheel turns.**
An AI tool can push any of the four elements in either direction, while generating lots of digital behavioral traces.
- That's exactly why we need to design AI for human agency and be able to concretely measure agency.**

PART 2 · REPEATABLE MOTIONS

**We create repeatable motions
based on our work with the
NGOs.**

Open-source tools, papers, and AI skills that connects psychological science with AI

A research library of agency interventions

A Google NotebookLM as an interactive agency intervention learning assistant

notebooklm.google.com · Agency-Based Intervention Assistant

Agency Intervention Learning Assistant by The Agency FundPublic

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Sources

+ Add sources

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Ecological Systems Theory

Implementation Science

Intervention Mapping

Planned Behavior Theory

Psychological Interventions

Self-Determination Theory

Social Cognitive Theory

Social Policy Research

Chat

Agency Intervention Learning Assistant by The Agency Fund

29 sources · Jan 3, 2026

Icek Ajzen's 1991 paper introduces the **Theory of Planned Behavior**, a psychological framework designed to predict and explain human actions. This model expands upon the earlier **Theory of Reasoned Action** by adding the concept of **perceived behavioral control**, which accounts for activities that individuals cannot fully influence through will alone. The author argues that **intentions**—driven by personal attitudes, social norms, and the perceived ease of an action—serve as the primary motivators for behavior. While empirical evidence largely supports the theory, the source also explores **unresolved issues** such as the role of past habits and the impact of moral obligations. Ultimately, the text demonstrates that combining **motivation and perceived ability** provides a highly accurate method for understanding how complex social behaviors are formed.

Save to note

Sunday, January 4

what is agency

Agency is the capacity to intentionally make things happen by one's actions; it involves the endowments, belief systems, and self-regulatory capabilities through which people exercise influence over the nature and quality of their lives. It is the essence of humanness.

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Gemini Notebook can be inaccurate; please double check its responses.

A research library of agency measurement tools

A Google NotebookLM for finding, comparing, and adapting agency measurement tools, co-developed with Google Jigsaw

notebooklm.google.com · Agency Measurement Tool Library

Measuring Agency in a Digital Context @ The Agency Fund & Jigsaw

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Political Science

Self-Efficacy

Social Behavior

Technology

Theories of Agency

GenAI Evaluation Playbook in the Development Se...

Chat

Measuring Agency in a Digital Context @ The Agency Fund & Jigsaw

184 sources · Jun 21, 2026

Customize

Welcome to this NotebookLM collection on **measuring agency in digital contexts**.

This notebook brings together theoretical papers, useful scales, and other resources on how agency can be understood, measured, and supported in digital environments. It was created as companion material for a blog drafted by [The Agency Fund](#) and [Jigsaw](#).

You can use this notebook to explore the research, compare measurement approaches, and brainstorm ideas for measuring agency in digital contexts. Please note that tags shown in the left sidebar are generated by NotebookLM.

Like any AI tool, NotebookLM can be helpful for thinking with documents, but it can also make mistakes. Please use it at your own discretion and refer back to the original sources when accuracy matters.

We hope this notebook serves as a useful starting point for research, discussion, and new ideas around measuring agency. We also welcome your feedback through [this form](#).

Creator Notes

Save to note

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Taxonomy of Agency and Agency-Related...

184 sources · 48d ago

Agency Map

184 sources · 48d ago

Agency Flashcards

184 sources · 48d ago

How AI erodes your agency

21:21 · Deep Dive · 182 sources · 56d ago

Add note

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A review paper that connects AI eval with cultural defaults

An interdisciplinary paper from the accelerator's AI eval working group, PNAS Nexus (under review)

PNAS Nexus, 2026, , 1–13
DOI added during production
Published: Date added during production
Paper



Evaluating AI Across Cultures: A Multilevel Framework for Generative AI in Global Development

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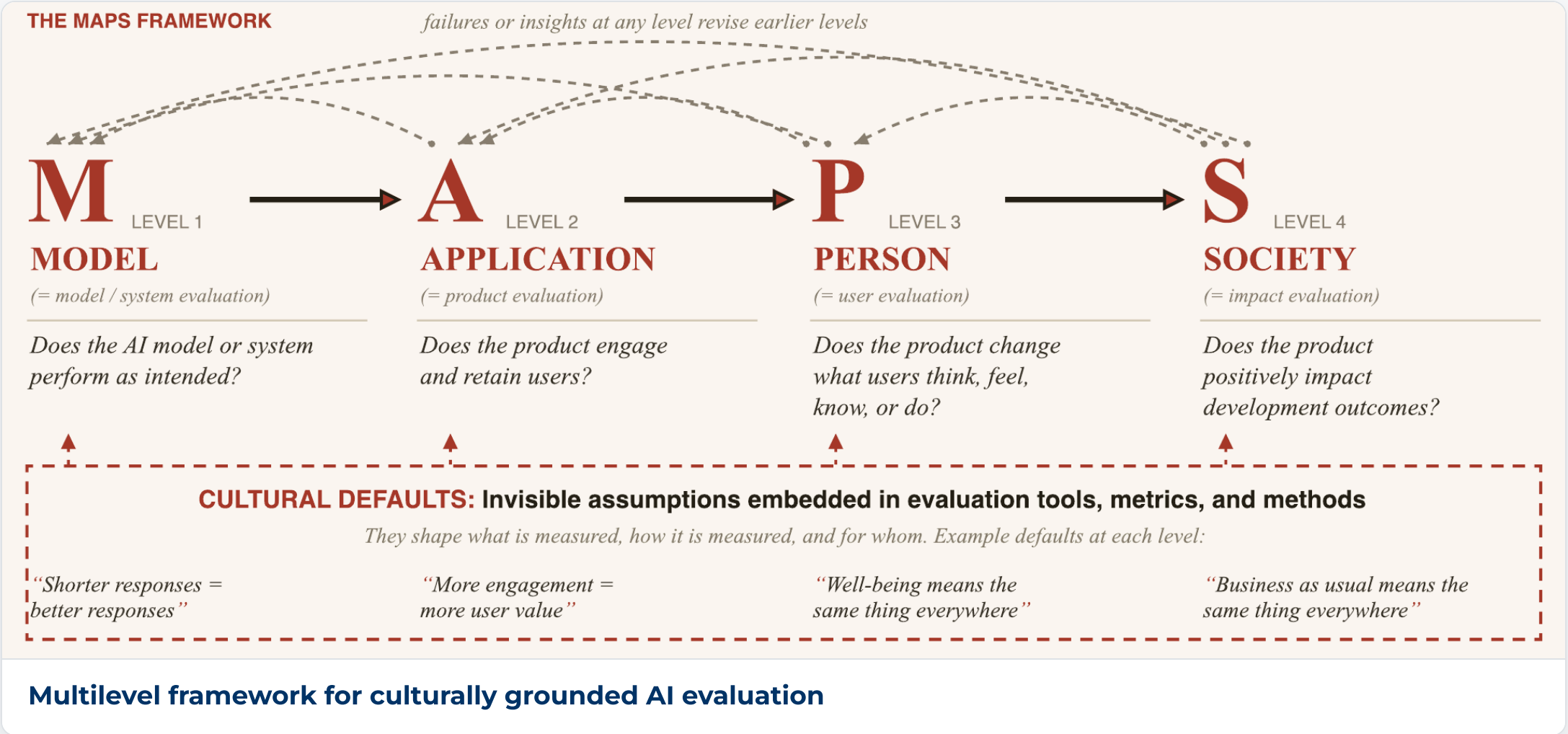
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⁶Center for Global Development, Washington, DC, USA
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⁸Microsoft Research, Bangalore, India
⁹Department of Computer Science, George Washington University, Washington, DC, USA
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Abstract

Generative AI tools are being deployed at scale across low- and middle-income countries as health chatbots, agricultural advisors, educational tutors, and beyond, yet the frameworks used to evaluate them were developed within Western, English-dominant, commercially oriented contexts. This cultural mismatch creates a structural problem: evaluation tools that function well in high-income settings can produce systematically flawed conclusions when applied to diverse global populations. Drawing on insights from a multidisciplinary working group spanning computer science, economics, behavioral science, public health, and linguistics, we introduce a four-level evaluation framework MAPS (the Model, its Application, the Person who uses it, and the Society it affects), designed to make explicit how culture shapes AI evaluation at every level. We argue that culture operates not as a moderating variable to be statistically controlled but as a set of defaults: invisible assumptions embedded in benchmarks, engagement metrics, psychological measures, and outcome assessments. When these defaults do not match the deployment context, evaluation produces artifacts rather than evidence. Grounding the framework in case studies from AI deployments across Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia, we show how culturally responsive evaluation differs from standard practice at each level and propose a research agenda for this emerging field.

Keywords artificial intelligence, culture, evaluation, global development, language diversity, WEIRD

Paper draft



Behavioral science skills that amplify existing AI workflows

Claude skills on behavioral science by The Agency Fund and Irrational Labs (e.g., [behavioural-skills](#); [taf-skills](#))

joe-speed.github.io/behavioural-skills

Behavioural Skills

CatalogueWorkflow BuilderPropose a Skill

Search

Star on GitHub

A curated, chainable library of atomic AI skills for behavioural science — each one narrow enough to describe without the word "and," built so one skill's output can feed the next.

Search skills by name or description...

CATEGORY

AllBehaviour DefinitionDiagnosisIntervention DesignMeasurementResearch MethodsSegmentation & PersonasRisk & Pre-MortemCultural ContextEvidence ScopingResearcher CalibrationContext MappingResearch Transparency

RESEARCH STAGE

AllPrepareDefineDiagnoseDesignTestMeasureReport

COM-B Barrier Decomposer

DiagnosisDiagnose

Use when one specific, already-defined target behaviour exists (a clear who + what + when, not a goal or outcome) and the question on the table is "why isn't this happening yet?"

Context & Audience Mapper

Context MappingPrepare

Use when a program goal names its target population only in the abstract identity terms a funder or stakeholder would use (e.g. "smallholder farmers", "gig workers", "first-time mothers") with no detail on the actual...

Install

Select skills from the list to build a combined install command.

INSTALL COMMAND

Copy, paste, run. Updates as you change platform or selection.

Platform

macOS / Linux

Selected: 0

BASH

Copy

```
curl -sSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Joe-Speed/behavioural-skills/main/scripts/install.sh | bash -s -- --target . --name <select-skills>
```

Advanced

Behavioral-science skills for applied AI workflows

Claude Skills · Agency Measurement

The Agency Fund

Afternoon, Zezhen

/ask-agency-measurement

what is agency and why should I measure it?

+Sonnet 4.6 High

Agency-measurement skills for research and evaluation

PART 3 · RESEARCH: DESIGNING AI FOR AGENCY

**We bring psychological science
into the design of AI products in
the social sector.**

We are working with several NGOs in the accelerator to test out preliminary ideas, but there are a lot of rooms for innovation in this design space.

Evaluating a medical professional copilot to align AI design with the agency of the humans in the loop

A mixed-methods case study with Noora Health and the Stanford Center for Health Education

THE SETTING

Noora Health's **Mobile Care Companion** answers families' health questions over WhatsApp. Since November 2025, a **GenAI copilot** reads incoming queries and drafts language-matched replies for Medical Support Executives (MSEs), who review, edit, and send every message. The copilot never faces patients: its effects run through MSE judgment.

240_k

queries per month across India

80_k

users reached monthly

15_k

health facilities

6

languages, Hindi to Odia

THE STUDY • CONCURRENT MIXED METHODS

Copilot access
9 MSEs

randomized 1:1,
by language

No copilot
9 MSEs

RQ1 How do MSEs with co-pilot access experience the tool, including changes in attitudes, trust, agency, and everyday practice? What do MSEs without co-pilot access expect or anticipate from such a tool?

RQ2 Is co-pilot access associated with measurable differences in RES conversations, including interactional dynamics, informational content, and rubric-defined quality, and do these patterns align with MSEs' reported experiences?

Method Concurrent mixed-methods design, combining semi-structured interviews with behavioral traces from AI interaction logs and quantitative analysis of patient-MSE conversations.

The value of the evaluation is to show how the co-pilot affects MSEs' judgment, agency, and communication in practice, so future iterations can **better support frontline decision-making without undermining the human role in care.**

Designing AI-personalized coaching to support field-agent agency in household behavior change

A design and evaluation study with Raising The Village's SBCC AI Coach

THE SETTING

Raising The Village's **SBCC AI Coach** generates personalized behavior-change coaching messages for last-mile households. Field agents review and deliver the messages across Uganda, Rwanda, and the Democratic Republic of Congo, so the AI intervention runs through human judgment rather than replacing it.

2,208

messages generated in the pilot

333

household check-ins covered

98.3%

rated helpful by field agents

97.1%

human and LLM rating agreement

THE STUDY • PERSONALIZATION AND ADOPTION

Design

Can AI-generated coaching make SBCC messages more **contextual, actionable, and culturally relevant** while preserving field agents' discretion?

Agency

Do agents experience the system as a tool that expands their coaching capacity, or as a script that narrows their professional judgment?

Measure

Track practice adoption, coaching coverage, field-agent knowledge, and household outcomes as the rollout moves from message-quality validation into impact evaluation.

Next

A cluster-randomized personalization trial is planned for the 2026B-2027 cycle against household outcomes.

The design question is whether AI can help field agents deliver better behavior-change support while **strengthening, rather than bypassing, the human relationships that make coaching work.**

There is a whole new field of literature on bringing psychology inside AI design and evaluation.

DESIGN

THE CORE ARGUMENT

Chatbots could democratize personalized support, or deepen isolation and risk. The difference is whether **psychological theory and methods are embedded** in design, evaluation, and monitoring, with concrete roles for psychologists across that whole pipeline.

FLIP BACK

ALIGNMENT

THE CORE ARGUMENT

AI should be understood as an **extension of human purposiveness**, grounded in practical autonomy: the human capacity to act for reasons and take responsibility. Alignment then runs through a normative interface connecting machine behavior to human norms, with humans remaining the ultimate bearers of responsibility.

FLIP BACK

EVALUATION

THE CORE ARGUMENT

Benchmarks reward accuracy, reasoning, and compliance, but say little about whether a system supports **user cognition, emotional interpretation, and behavioral decision-making** in ways fit for the user and context. The authors propose testing this with scenario-based probes and structured human and model-assisted evaluation.

FLIP BACK

FIELD

THE CORE ARGUMENT

AI systems increasingly mediate social, cultural, economic, and political interaction. Understanding their effects requires an interdisciplinary **science of machine behavior** that combines computer science with behavioral, social, and cognitive science methods.

FLIP BACK

We also see a unique opportunity in bringing the **science of wise psychological interventions** into AI design.

We are working on practical guidelines and papers for agency-supportive AI using wise intervention techniques.

- Education assistants that protect belonging by helping users interpret struggle as a normal part of learning, rather than evidence that "people like me don't belong here."
- Health or livelihoods coaches that strengthen users' sense of control by helping them recognize meaningful choices and act on options available to them.
- AI messaging tools that deliberately test how small changes in language shape identity, social norms, and motivation - for example, framing an action as part of "who I am," not just something to do.

We create tools for **measuring agency in human-AI interactions.**

Agency can be experienced internally or expressed externally through choices and actions. There is also a wide array of on-platform and off-platform data that we can use to concretely understand and measure context-specific agencies.

We created a guideline for **measuring agency in a digital context**

[A practitioner's guide](#) co-cocreated with Google Jigsaw



Summary

- The Agency Fund and Google Jigsaw have co-developed a free set of resources and AI tools to help measure how digital and AI tools shape human agency in practice: an open-source [Claude Skill](#) that helps you brainstorm alongside this blog and a curated [NotebookLM](#) with useful papers and measurement approaches.
- **Why should tech teams care about agency?** Research increasingly shows that digital and AI tools can expand human agency; but when poorly designed or implemented, they can also undermine it.
- **What is agency in the context of digital and AI tools?** Agency is a person's capability to navigate toward the future they want. It can be experienced internally (e.g., feeling capable or empowered) or expressed externally through choices and actions. Agency may concern a user's end goals independent of technology, or their ability to shape, control, and effectively use a tool in pursuit of those goals.
- **How do we measure agency?** It should be measured as an outcome, not inferred from engagement alone. Teams should specify what agency means for their specific users and contexts. We suggest three broad steps:
 - Define agency for your local problem
 - Choose the right measurement tools for the right type of on-platform or off-platform data, measured at the right moment
 - Test and validate the measurement tools iteratively

What you need to measure also depends on the forms of agency and how agency manifests in your product.

Hypothetical example: an AI mentor helping learners develop a viable business idea

Agency with respect to the end goals

Can users make progress toward outcomes they value, whether through, around, or beyond the tool?

Internally experienced agency

People's thoughts and feelings

ON-PLATFORM DATA • IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY
Short in-app surveys probing users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived control over their ultimate goal over time (e.g., "How confident is the user about developing a successful business idea? How much control do they feel over reaching their ultimate goal?")



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • PHONE OR IN-PERSON SURVEY
Longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that systematically probe users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived control over their ultimate goal over time.



FLIP BACK

Externally expressed agency

People's choices and actions

ON-PLATFORM DATA • CONVERSATION LOGS
Longitudinal user signals of agency in AI conversation logs, especially those related to setting and navigating longer-term goals or demonstrating resilience despite difficulties.



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • RUBRIC-RATED PITCHES
Longer phone/in-person surveys tracking how users develop their business ideas; rubric-rated observations of ideas and pitches; or classroom observation of teamwork, ideally linked to downstream outcomes like business earnings.



FLIP BACK

Agency with respect to the AI tool

Can users understand, question, adapt, and control the tool, deciding when and how to rely on it?

ON-PLATFORM DATA • IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY
Short in-app surveys probing whether users felt able to understand, question, or adapt an AI mentor's advice.



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • VALIDATED SCALES
Longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that systematically probe users' trust in IA and perceived dependence versus empowerment when using a tool.



FLIP BACK

ON-PLATFORM DATA • DIGITAL TRACES
Whether users understand, question, or adapt an AI mentor's advice. Digital traces (e.g., interaction patterns or conversation logs) showing



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • OBSERVATION AND INTERVIEWS
Observation or interview data (e.g., usability studies) on tool usage for developing business ideas.

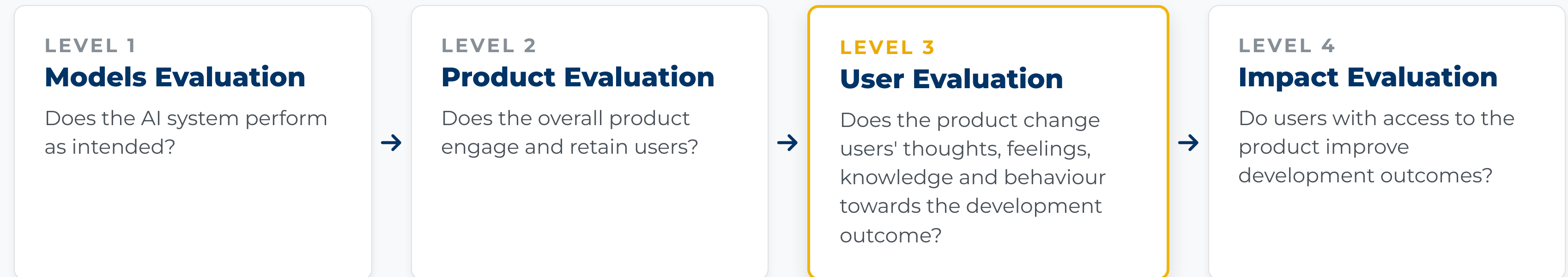


FLIP BACK

 **Mind the social setting:** norms and relationships can also shape these questions; interpret the answers in your users' contexts.

Agency measurement sits at **Level 3**

The four-level evaluation framework · eval.playbook.org.ai



Nobody can run an RCT on every product change. **Validated agency measures at Level 3** move when the product changes, and they speak to what Level 4 cares about. That also allows teams to anchor their A/B tests on intermediate measures that are psychologically and behaviorally meaningful and relatively easy to collect.

Teams should specify what agency means for **their specific users and contexts**

1

Define agency for your local problem

What kind of agency is the tool supposed to support? **For whom? To what end?** Anchor the definition in your program's theory of change.



2

Measure with the right tools, on the right data, at the right moment

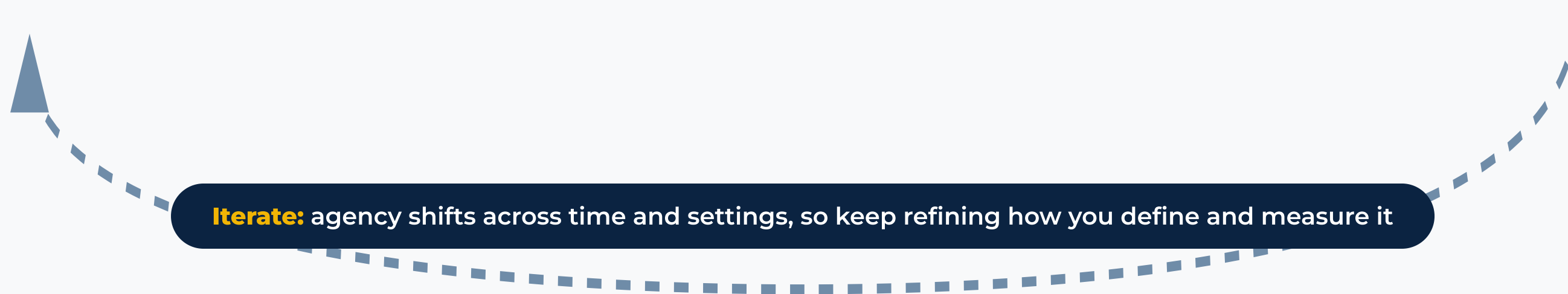
Combine **on-platform** signals, such as in-app surveys and digital traces, with **off-platform** surveys, interviews, observations, and records.



3

Test and validate your measurement tools iteratively

Test for evidence of **reliability and validity** for your context.



Workshops help NGOs identify signals of agency in human-AI conversations.

From abstract construct to labelable conversation evidence.

Agriculture AI Advisor — Agency Coding

AGR-10 - Chebet's group vaccination worked

Previous

Item 1 of 10

Next

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

UIJSON

newcastle update. we vaccinated. 5 of us shared one vial, 60 bob each instead of 300

6/24/2026, 3:10:00 PM

Agent

The group-buy done exactly right — one vial covers 100 birds and never keeps once opened. How many birds did you cover between you?

6/24/2026, 3:12:13 PM

mine 18, group total about 70. before the vaccine i lost 2 chicks in one week. since then zero, 3 weeks now

6/24/2026, 3:15:39 PM

the booster is already agreed for august 20, same group

6/24/2026, 3:17:18 PM

Agent

Two losses to zero, and the booster already booked — well organised! Anything else for the flock?

6/24/2026, 3:20:10 PM

feed. mash is 3200 per 70kg and the egg money is not matching it

6/24/2026, 3:23:15 PM

Description

Agricultural advisory chatbot for smallh Kericho, 18 chickens plus a small tea pl Newcastle disease three weeks ago aft chicks.

Comments (optional)

Add any notes about this item

Q1: Motivation

Does the user seem more motivated to tak

Yes

The signal is clearly present in the user's messages.

No

The sign in the us

Reasoning (optional)

Add your reasoning

Q2: Action and choice

Does the user say what they decided to do already done?

Yes

The signal is clearly present in the user's

No

The sign

If agency matters to a product's theory of change, it has to be **measured as an outcome**, not treated as a nice story after launch.

1 Ground labels in use cases. Participants label synthetic conversations inspired by accelerator products in maternal health, agriculture, and entrepreneurship.

2 Use a simple binary rubric. Look for motivation, action and choice, links between advice and outcomes, and updated mental models.

3 Keep the reasoning. Calibrate stores each label and the labeler's explanation, then runs an LLM judge with the same instructions.

4 Use disagreement as data. Human-human, human-LLM, and score-note disagreement sharpen the rubric before scaling to more conversations.

Sources: [Nairobi agency measurement workshop slides](#) · [Labeling human agency in human-AI conversations](#).

The flagship study: Measuring agency in a digital context

Proposal · with Hamsa Bastani and Osbert Bastani, University of Pennsylvania · six NGO partners

MAIN IDEAS FROM THE PROPOSAL

Use LLMs to measure whether digital platforms strengthen people's agency.

- 1 Start from real traces:** text, voice, video, decisions, and linked outcomes from digital and AI products.
- 2 Judge agency beyond product engagement:** e.g., score intentionality, forethought, self-reactiveness, and self-reflectiveness.
- 3 Track change over time:** estimate agency at key moments and mark uncertainty when evidence is thin.
- 4 Validate lightly:** combine expert labels with targeted surveys where they add the most information.

The practical output is a **shared measurement tool** that helps product teams improve outcomes through the lens of agency.



Jacaranda Health
HEALTH · KENYA

Agency signal: how mothers ask, decide, and follow care pathways in PROMPTS conversations, linked where possible to care-seeking and visits.

DG

Digital Green
LIVELIHOODS · KENYA, ETHIOPIA, INDIA

Agency signal: whether FarmerChat users move from advice-seeking to applying or sharing agronomy guidance across product versions.



Kabakoo Academies
LIVELIHOODS · MALI

Agency signal: learner voice/video reflections that reveal goals, confidence, follow-through, and later livelihood progress.

N

Nova Escola
EDUCATION · BRAZIL

Agency signal: how teachers use a WhatsApp lesson-planning copilot to co-create, adapt, and reuse classroom plans.

APPRENTICE

The Apprentice Project
EDUCATION · INDIA

Agency signal: students' creativity, persistence, and next choices after TAP Buddy feedback, including mother-tongue voice interactions.



Udhyam Learning Foundation
EDUCATION · INDIA

Agency signal: chat and submission traces that show grit, motivation, self-efficacy, and entrepreneurial follow-through.

**Let's build AI that
strengthens human agency,
and **prove that it does.****